

How to Ask the Troubleshooting Agent Good Questions

A quick guide to writing prompts that get accurate, useful answers

Why This Matters

The agent answers strictly from indexed documentation (or your uploaded file, in temporary mode) — it will not guess or fill gaps with outside knowledge. This is intentional, so answers stay trustworthy. It also means the **quality of your question directly affects the quality of the answer**: a vague question retrieves vague context; a specific question retrieves the exact section that answers it.

1. Pick the Right Mode First

Before typing your question, choose the correct mode in the app:

- **Knowledge Base** — for questions about vendor documentation, SOPs, or past tickets already indexed (Veeam, NetApp, VMware, Dell EMC, ExaGrid, Hitachi, Microsoft/Hyper-V).
- **Temporary Document** — for questions about a file you're uploading just for this session (not saved, not searchable later).

In Knowledge Base mode, also select a **category** (e.g., "veeam" or "netapp") if you know which vendor your question relates to — this narrows the search and gives faster, more precise answers. Use "All" only when you're not sure, or your question spans multiple vendors.

2. Be Specific — Name the Product, Version, and Symptom

The agent retrieves based on matching words and meaning. Vague questions retrieve vague or scattered context.

Weak:

"backup failed, help"

Better:

"Veeam Backup & Replication job fails with 'insufficient disk space' error on the repository — what are the recommended steps?"

Weak:

"hyper-v limits"

Better:

"What is the maximum number of virtual processors supported per VM in Windows Server 2025 Hyper-V?"

3. Ask One Question at a Time

Bundling multiple unrelated questions into one message makes retrieval less precise, since the agent searches using your question's overall meaning. Split multi-part questions into separate messages for better accuracy.

Weak:

"What is ONTAP, what is AFF, and how do I set up SnapMirror?"

Better:

Ask three separate messages: "What is ONTAP?" then "What is AFF?" then "How do I set up SnapMirror?"

4. Follow-Up Questions — Add Context, Don't Assume It's Remembered Perfectly

The agent does carry conversation history, so short follow-ups like "elaborate" or "what about for Nutanix?" generally work. But for best results, especially if you've asked several questions in a row, re-mention the specific topic rather than relying purely on a one-word follow-up.

Works, but riskier:

"elaborate"

More reliable:

"elaborate on active-active multipathing for AFF systems"

5. Understand What "I Don't Know" Means

If the agent says the documentation doesn't answer your question, this usually means one of two things:

- The information genuinely isn't in the indexed documents yet (common for very foundational terms vendor manuals assume you already know, like basic acronym definitions).
- Your question used different terminology than the document — try rephrasing with the exact product/error name if you know it.

This is deliberate: the agent is built to never invent infrastructure details it isn't sure of. An honest "not found" is safer than a confident guess.

6. Uploading Your Own Documents

If you have a document relevant to your question that isn't already indexed:

- **Permanent (Add to Knowledge Base):** use this if the document should be searchable by everyone, going forward. Pick the correct vendor category when uploading.
- **Temporary:** use this if you just need answers from one document for your current task, and it shouldn't be added to the shared knowledge base.

Quick Reference: Good Prompt Checklist

- Did I pick the right mode (Knowledge Base vs. Temporary Document)?

- Did I select the right category, if I know the vendor?
- Did I name the specific product, version, and symptom/error?
- Am I asking one question, not several bundled together?
- If this is a follow-up, did I restate the topic instead of just saying "elaborate" or "why"?